

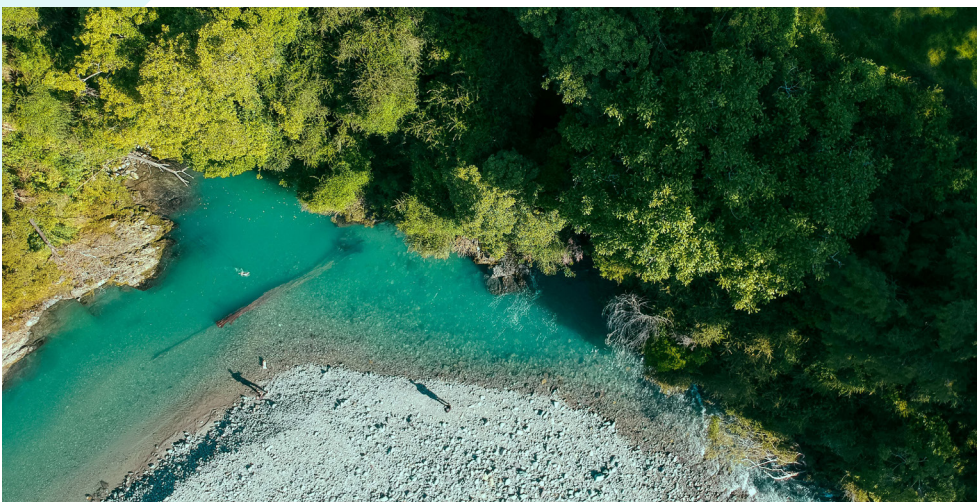
Clean Up Politics

Democracy means rule by the people. Clean Up Politics is Opportunity's plan to make sure the people of New Zealand rule this country. Opportunity will hard-wire honesty, transparency, and genuine public participation into our democracy, so that corruption and the abuse of power cannot take hold.

New Zealand has long prided itself on low corruption and high trust. But we can't assume that a historically clean political culture will always protect us. A recent Serious Fraud Office [assessment](#) concluded that the risk of corruption is increasing, incidents are under-reported and government agencies are insufficiently prepared to prevent and respond to corrupt practices. New Zealand needs modern, world-leading rules that keep pace with growing private and foreign influence in politics, expanding political lobbying, and increasingly centralised executive power.

At present, New Zealand has no overall caps on political donations, and reporting thresholds permit donors to pay significant sums to parties with limited transparency. Lobbyists enjoy easy access to politicians. They have no register, no enforceable code of conduct, and no obligation to disclose whom they meet or act for. New Zealand has no central body responsible for addressing corruption. Transparency International and local experts have repeatedly warned that these gaps create risks and public perceptions of policy being 'for sale'.

Opportunity will work across Parliament to lock in a bold, long-term package of reforms built on three pillars.



1. Regulate lobbying

Recent controversies have shown how difficult it can be for the public to see who influences important government decisions, what interests they represent, and what contact they have had with decision-makers. Opportunity will introduce a Political Influence and Lobbying Bill that creates:

- A one-year cooling-off period closing the revolving door between Ministers, senior staff and officials, and lobbying roles.
- A mandatory, public, searchable lobbying register, with quarterly disclosure of who lobbied which office-holders, on what issues, for which clients.
- A statutory code of conduct for lobbyists, with sanctions from public censure to deregistration and fines. The code will include:
 - A prohibition on contingent-fee arrangements for securing specific policy outcomes or contracts;
 - Requirements to avoid conflicts of interest among clients and declare relevant financial interests;
 - Transparency rules for communicating which clients they are working on behalf of and what their objectives are;
 - Requiring that all lobbying communications with Ministers concerning official business be conducted through, copied to, or recorded in official parliamentary systems so that they are retained and subject to the OIA;
 - Confidentiality rules for dealing with client and government information.
- Foreign lobbying safeguards, with disclosure of foreign state or foreign-controlled clients and heightened scrutiny of lobbying on critical infrastructure, national security, media ownership, and strategic resources.

2. Reform political donations

New Zealanders believe money buys access and influence in politics. A 2020 Victoria University of Wellington survey found 34% of the public believed corruption was widespread throughout Government, and 71% had 'not much' or 'little to no' trust in how political parties are funded. Opportunity will sever the link between donations and influence, and make politics a competition of ideas, not fundraising machines.

- A \$30,000 cap per donor per party per electoral cycle. The Independent Electoral Review proposed an electoral donations cap at this level. Loan-as-donation structures and pass-through arrangements will be banned.
- Only registered voters may donate. Opportunity will eliminate donations from companies, trusts and other entities, and ban donations from anyone who is not registered to vote in New Zealand.
- Lower disclosure limits. Opportunity will lower the public disclosure threshold to \$1,000 and require parties to publish audited annual statements.
- Spending limits across the full cycle. Party and candidate advertising spending limits will apply across the full three-year electoral cycle, not just the final three months, with the Electoral Commission publishing quarterly spending summaries.

3. An integrity system that works

Good rules mean little without institutions that enforce them. Opportunity will establish a genuinely independent anti-corruption body with investigative, prevention, and education functions, integrating and co-ordinating existing anti-corruption responsibilities. It will cover the full range of public officials, including Ministers, MPs, parliamentary staff, the public service, Crown entities, SOEs, local government, and contractors performing public functions. Its responsibilities will include:

- Investigating - including by compelling evidence and exercising search and surveillance powers under judicial warrant - and exposing corruption. This will include publicising findings as well as referring matters for prosecution to other bodies such as the Serious Fraud Office or Police.
- Enforcing new rules that prohibit authorised electoral advertisements containing statements of fact that are inaccurate and misleading to a material extent, backed by the requirement to publish corrections.
- Monitoring and reporting on systemic risk of corruption overall within the public service.
- Administering the lobbying rules described above.
- Educating the public sector on integrity and corruption
- Ensuring government entities have appropriate internal prevention and response measures in place.

Alongside the anti-corruption body, Opportunity will upgrade the day-to-day integrity rules:

- Official Information Act reform: narrower withholding grounds, strengthening the public interest balancing test, enforceable timeframes for actually providing documents and binding order-making powers for the Ombudsman.
- Stronger pecuniary interest rules: lower disclosure thresholds, mandatory disclosure of beneficial interests in trusts, and real-time reporting of significant changes.
- Better whistleblower protections, with broader coverage, safe channels to the anti-corruption body and other enforcement bodies, and stronger protection against retaliation.
- A stronger Electoral Commission with the funding and powers to enforce the rules in real time.
- An independent policy costing unit available to all registered parties, to reduce fiscal 'spin wars' and improve the quality of election debates.